

To: Christina Sun, instructor of English 379

From: Amy Flynn, student

Subject: A Report on the Feasibility of Submitting a Proposal Seeking Funding For an Event Series Promoting Sustainable Fashion Practice On-Campus

Date: November 2, 2022

Purpose:

The purpose of this memo is to analyze the feasibility of writing a grant proposal to the University of Massachusetts Amherst on behalf of Fashion Revolution USA for an on-campus event series meant to promote knowledge of sustainable fashion.

Summary:

This report speaks to the feasibility of acquiring funding from the University of Massachusetts Amherst for an on-campus event series focused on the initiation and education of sustainable fashion practices among the student body and the surrounding community. Non-sustainable fashion practices account for a shockingly significant portion of the climate crisis, particularly in younger demographics given the rise of fast fashion via online shopping. The proposed event series would involve a monthly large-scale swap/tag sale open to students and the public. The working plan for the events involves opportunities for students to sell and barter used clothing or things, local non-profit thrift stores to promote themselves to the student body and surrounding community, and Fashion Revolution USA to educate a larger audience about their mission of sustainable fashion practices. It would also allow the University of Massachusetts Amherst the opportunity to further its commitment to sustainability on campus and promote campus engagement among the student body post-pandemic.

Discussion:

The climate crisis is one of the most serious issues our world is facing with no clear end in sight due to the inaction of governments and organizations. Many people are unaware of the fashion industry's shockingly significant part of the climate crisis. 10% of carbon emissions are produced by the fashion industry, and it consumes the second-most amount of water as any other industry. It also contributes to general mass waste, labor issues in factory working conditions, and ocean pollution from microplastics in fibers. This is especially problematic because fashion has been overly commodified with the advent of the Internet; in fact, consumers are buying 60% more clothing than previously and wearing them for half the time they used to in the United States.¹

As such, this project would aim to set up a series of on-campus events to initiate and educate the student body and the surrounding community about the role the fashion industry plays in the climate crisis. Beyond redesigning materials to contribute to a circular economy or changing corporation behavior, sustainable fashion experts have expressed that buying secondhand or repurposing clothes is one of the best ways individuals can help combat the fashion-induced crisis.² As such, this project would consist of a monthly series of large-scale swap/tag sales where people could swap or sell old clothes and items to promote the redistribution of products. We believe it would be beneficial to keep it open to the public as well as partner with local nonprofit thrift shops to drum up attendance. People could register in advance if they had many items to bring or bring things last-minute to a section open for individual swapping and selling. We would propose eight monthly events during the academic year starting in September 2023 and going through May 2024, excluding December 2023 because of winter break. The grant

¹ Per the 2020 edition of *Proceedings of the Northeast Business & Economics Association*

² <https://news.climate.columbia.edu/2021/06/10/why-fashion-needs-to-be-more-sustainable/>

proposal would only cover funds for that first year, and we would ensure that our progress was tracked diligently so as to hopefully prove success and acquire funding for following years.

The request for funding is on behalf of Fashion Revolution USA from the University of Massachusetts Amherst. Fashion Revolution USA is a chapter of the internationally-based organization Fashion Revolution, and it specifically places significant focus on events and education “to help create an inclusive U.S. fashion system that conducts business ethically, regenerates the environment, and produces responsibly, supporting all voices across the apparel network.”³ The Education team of Fashion Revolution USA is well-versed in dealing with higher education and has previously worked on partnerships with universities, which should appeal to the University of Massachusetts Amherst as a serious candidate for funding.

The proposed grant and project is also beneficial for the University of Massachusetts Amherst. Given the severity of the climate crisis, college campuses are being pushed towards making choices in the effort of greater sustainability. In just the last few years, UMass has installed the largest campus solar panel network in New England, committed to changing to 100% renewable energy and laid out a comprehensive ten year energy plan, and participates in the Real Food Project as well as the Campus Race to Zero Waste Competition.⁴ The campus is obviously committed to working on the climate crisis, but there has been no concrete actions towards the issues of sustainable fashion. This proposal allows them to take even more action on their pledge of sustainability by partnering with Fashion Revolution USA to promote sustainability and educate its community. As mentioned above, we strongly feel that the events should be open to the public and allow vetted local nonprofits like the Hospice Shop of the Fisher Home, located

³ <https://www.fashionrevolution.org/north-america/usa/>

⁴ <https://www.umass.edu/sustainability/climate-change-energy>

in Amherst, and the Cancer Connection Thrift Shop, located in Northampton, to participate. The University of Massachusetts Amherst describes itself as a “leader in sustainable development and education for the community, state, and nation.”⁵ This would go even further towards the University’s mission of promoting sustainability for the broader state and community, not just the student body.

This project would also be beneficial for the University of Massachusetts Amherst to promote campus engagement. The University is dealing with a student population that almost half of which has a limited experience with on-campus life. There has been a push to reintegrate people into campus life and return the University of Massachusetts Amherst to its pre-pandemic prime. Hosting events like this that are easy and free for students to attend while making strides towards sustainability is extremely valuable.

The general plan of execution for this event series starts with the hiring of an event coordinator. This would not be a full-time paid position, but rather a stipend based on part-time planning for the eight events. Once the coordinator was hired, it would be their job to plan the event in tandem with Fashion Revolution USA and the university. Ideally, the actual event would include sections (i.e tables or booths) for the student body and the public to sell or swap, for local vetted thrift shops to bring inventory of their choice, and for education about sustainable fashion with experts from Fashion Revolution USA or on-campus organizations geared towards sustainable practices. Once the event was planned, the coordinator would be responsible for marketing it appropriately. More research has to be done on the best market tactics and the costs. Ideally, the event could be held outside on Goodell Lawn when weather permitted, but to avoid paying for space it could otherwise be held in the free space of the Campus Center basement. We also

⁵ <https://www.umass.edu/sustainability/about>

believe in placing an emphasis on tracking the success/progress of the event by hiring a professional photographer, having people sign in, and getting feedback so as to improve and sustain the event for more years.

More research must be done to establish the exact amount this grant will be asking for, but some preliminary budget analysis shows that it will be in the range of \$5,000 to \$10,000. This is based on rough estimates of a monthly event planner's stipend for eight months worth of events of the academic year, plus the costs of the event including tables, hangars, space, marketing materials, and some kind of other draw like music and/or refreshments. However, we will have to look at other similar events on UMass and other campuses to get a point of reference. As can be seen below, we've established our first order of business on our timeline to finalize our research on fashion sustainability, and secondly to establish the exact budget breakdown.

Task	Timeline for 2022	Team
Finalize research	November 2 - November 7	Education
Calculate and write exact budget	November 2 - November 7	Strategic Initiatives & Creative Programming
Finalize event plan	November 8 - November 15	Strategic Initiatives & Creative Programming
Create and write marketing plan	November 8 - November 15	Communications
Write other body elements	November 15 - December 1	Communications
Write end matter	December 2- December 5	Communications
Write front matter	December 5 - December 8	Communications
Edit draft	December 8 - December 18	All
Finalize & submit grant	December 18	All

In addition, we believe we can show the prospects of the event series are extremely positive. The campus has already recognized this issue on a small scale; the Civic Engagement and Service Learning program has a weekly item swap, the Sustainable Business and Fashion club works towards promoting sustainability on campus, and many people attend the farmers markets on Goodell lawn where there are occasionally tables with secondhand items. Though admirable that members of the campus community have recognized the lack of engagement in this area, it speaks to how much of a need there is for this to happen on a larger scale. Fashion Revolution USA would be happy to work with any interested parties on campus directly. Our main goal is to bring these efforts into one cohesive space focused on outreach and education, partnered with the community towards a better future.

Conclusion:

Writing a grant proposal on behalf of Fashion Revolution USA to the University of Massachusetts Amherst appears to be feasible. It will require more research on exact budgetary expenses as well as finalizing research on sustainable fashion to be presented in the proposal, but our preliminary research is very promising. The aim of this event series is to promote sustainability on campus and in the surrounding community through repurposing and recycling secondhand goods, which is a common goal of both the University and Fashion Revolution USA. Per our research, it would benefit both parties through sustainability initiatives and community engagement. The next steps will be to put together a thorough and cohesive grant proposal to present to the University of Massachusetts Amherst, starting with finalizing sustainability research and budget expenses.

Sources

1. Mott, Ryan, et al. "The Sustainable Closet." *Proceedings of the Northeast Business & Economics Association*, Jan. 2020, pp. 111–14. *EBSCOhost*,
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2. Renee Cho|June, et al. "Why Fashion Needs to Be More Sustainable." *State of the Planet*, 16 Dec. 2021,
<https://news.climate.columbia.edu/2021/06/10/why-fashion-needs-to-be-more-sustainable/>.
3. "Fashion Revolution USA." *USA : Fashion Revolution*,
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4. "Sustainability." *UMass Amherst*,
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5. "Sustainability." *UMass Amherst*, <https://www.umass.edu/sustainability/about>.